

Swift Playgrounds

Learn coding the easy way; no prior background required.

Varad Choudhari
readersletters@digit.in

Apple launched iOS 10 last month with their trademark pomp and splendor. With this update, some of the existing features stand polished, making the operating system better than ever. But the most significant development of all is that Apple now has a new foundation to offer called “Swift Playgrounds”.

That Apple has always had the alacrity to make things easier for its developers is no breaking news. The introduction of the Swift language, then, is simply one of its preliminary steps towards attracting more developers. And going a good few steps ahead, Apple is now targeting school kids and attempting to instill programming skills into the young minds with the help of Swift Playgrounds.

What is Swift Playgrounds?

Swift Playgrounds is a free iPad app from Apple which aims to help kids to code in the Swift Programming language. The app uses a unique interactive method where you have to control a character called “Byte” by writing code. All the instructions are written clearly, thanks to which you don’t require any coding skills to start working with Playgrounds. Additionally, you are also offered pseudo-IDE to write and run your own code on the device.

How to get Swift Playgrounds?

Swift Playgrounds is available free of cost on the App Store. Unfortunately, it

only works on the iPad at this moment. Your iPad needs to be running iOS 10 in order to get the app.

Getting started with Swift Playgrounds

On launching the app, you’ll be taken through an introductory video and then to the Playgrounds window. You’ll be presented with two tabs: Featured and My Playgrounds.

If you tap the former, you’ll be presented with two introductory lessons: Fundamentals of Swift and Beyond the Basics. There’s another section called “Challenges” where you can apply your existing skills.

To start with, select “Fundamentals of Swift”. You need to download this lesson from the App Store, which you can do by tapping the “GET” button located right below the cover photo. Meanwhile, you could go through the screenshots and read the description.

You’ll see the course under the My Playgrounds tab. Click on the icon and a tutorial will be presented to you. Go through it to get the idea of what you are supposed to do in this lesson. The tutorial ends by asking you to write some code.

You’ll see some instructions followed by an empty space where you have to write your code on the left side of the screen and an interactive animation consisting of a character named “Byte” on the right. You’ll see a path

made of stones, some stairs and finally a red gem.

Your goal in this session is to collect the gem. To do this, you need to write some easy Swift commands such as “moveForward()” and “collectGem()”. Start writing the command by selecting “Tap to enter code” below the instructions. A toolbar will now appear at the bottom of the screen showing you the two necessary commands. Tap the



Use appropriate moves to make Byte collect the gem.

button “moveForward()” and your command will be listed under the instructions. Hit the “Run my code” button located at the bottom of the interactive animation so that the command is reflected on the character. You’ll now see the Byte moving forward.

You may have noticed that the character moved ahead by a single tile. This is because you entered the “moveForward()” command only once. To make it reach the gem, you have to enter the command three times, followed by “collectGem()”. Hit the run button and your